

are sometimes grown through plastic sheeting, since this warms the soil, prevents the fruits from being splashed with mud, and also suppresses weeds. Create a 3 ft (1 m) wide mound of soil the length of your desired row. Lay a sheet of plastic over it and then bury the sheet's edges so that it is weighed down tight. Cut slits and plant the runners through it.

If there is a risk of frost, cover young plants with a cloche or cold frame (see image, right). When you buy your plants, be sure that they are certified disease-free.

CROP CARE

Ensure that plants are kept well-watered—especially those in containers, since their soil will dry out much faster than those



Protect young plants with a cloche.

planted in the ground. However, be careful not to overwater the plants. Take care not to splash the berries when watering, since this may encourage them to rot. Feed plants with a balanced fertilizer in early to mid-spring.

To prevent unprotected fruits from sitting directly in the soil, it is common to mulch around

TIP **MULCHING**

Mulching around your plants with straw serves many useful purposes: it keeps fruits ventilated and dry, while keeping them from getting covered with soil, and protects crowns from cold in winter.

- Carefully lift the plant's leaves and fruits and tuck a thick layer of clean, dry straw underneath them.
- Place strawberry mats around plant stems. Mats can be dried, brushed off, and reused the following year.



Keeping fruits dry and cushioned minimizes the risk of them rotting.